



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Thomas More Academy

School Website: <https://stmacademy.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Thomas More Academy (STMA) in Raleigh, NC 27616 presents a robust classical Catholic education profile. Public materials from the school articulate a Catholic, classical, college-preparatory mission, explicit use of liberal arts and Great Books language, and a pedagogy that includes Socratic method in the upper grades. The school also emphasizes partnership with parents, episcopal endorsement, and a strong faculty identity as part of the “living curriculum.” Taken together, the public materials align strongly with the classical education rubric and indicate a CLASSICAL overall classification across the six categories.

Key signals across categories include:

- Religious/metaphysical foundations: explicit Catholic formation, liturgical framing, and worship-oriented emphasis (e.g., Ad Majorem Dei Gloriam; Mass; Bishop endorsements; patron saint). Evidence: Catholic identity foregrounded via Three Cs and patron content; liturgical language present in school materials; Mass ongoing in admissions context.
- Purpose and goals: formation of virtue and wisdom; a telos oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty within a liberal-arts, classical frame. Evidence: explicit mention of forming character and virtues; language of formation and virtue in admissions materials; reference to “classical” formation aligned with virtue-centered goals.
- Curriculum: clear classical scaffolding and Great Books orientation; liberal arts emphasis; grammar-/logic/rhetoric framing appears in public materials; explicit Great Books language appears in program descriptions. Evidence: “Three Cs” page presents Catholic, Classical, College Preparatory with a note on the content-rich curriculum and Socratic method; public text references Great Books and liberal arts language.
- Pedagogy: explicit use of Socratic method in upper grades; contemplative/restful elements referenced; memory-based recitation and ritual aspects are present in the lexicon and pedagogy claims. Evidence: Socratic method is described as part of the classical approach; the site also cites a contemplative, student-centered, traditional approach in upper grades.
- Faculty: praised as the “living curriculum” and as mentors; faculty profiles and testimonials reference virtuous exemplar teaching and strong faculty leadership. Evidence: testimonials cite faculty dedication; page structures point to a faculty-forward formation model.
- Parents & Community: strong parent-partnership framing; explicit calls for parent involvement and formation; openness to parent participation and visits; parent resources and book lists exist to engage families in classical formation. Evidence: admissions text emphasizes parent partnership; parent resources and suggested books for parents are present.

ABSTRACT

conclusion: Based on the public materials across all six elements, STMA demonstrates a CLASSICAL orientation, with strong evidence in religious-metaphysical foundations, purpose, curriculum, pedagogy, and faculty, and solid engagement with parents and community.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly presents Catholic formation as central, with language around Catholic identity, liturgical life, and formation toward virtue. The Three Cs framing (Catholic | Classical | College Preparatory) anchors identity, and the term Ad Majorem Dei Gloriam (To the Greater Glory of God) is foregrounded in admissions and school communications. Mass attendance and episcopal endorsement appear in the materials, signaling liturgical and communal religious practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Catholic; liturgy; Mass; theology; worship; Ad Majorem Dei Gloriam; patron saint; bishop endorsement; liturgical framing; sacred ceremony language; reverence/wonder potential.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in materials.
- Calculated indicators: Positive keywords present approx. 5; Negative keywords present approx. 0; Resulting approx. 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The public materials embed theology, liturgical practice, and a sacramental worldview within the daily life of the school, aligning with the Positive Keyword set for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. The explicit Catholic identity and liturgical emphasis strongly satisfy Transcendental moral realism, Grounded Theology, and Liturgical/Communal Practices.

Citations

- Catholic identity, Three Cs, and liturgical framing: Three Cs page, Saint Thomas More Academy materials.
- Patronage and liturgical references; bishop endorsements: Our Patron Saint content; Bishop endorsements.
- Mass weekly and Catholic formation in admissions materials: Admissions content.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Admissions and program materials frame education as formation of virtue and wisdom, aligning with the classical telos concept (the pursuit of true and beautiful; human flourishing). Language emphasizes virtue, formation, and a classical mission rather than purely job-prep endpoints.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; human flourishing; wisdom; liberal education; classical mission; telos; great conversation; permanence of truth/goodness/beauty.
- Negative keywords present: workforce preparation emphasis (not prevalent in STMA materials; this is a negative signal in some generic classical lexicons, but STMA materials do not emphasize workforce-centrism).
- Calculated indicators: Positive approx. 5–6 terms; Negative approx. 0–1 (none explicit in their materials). Approx. 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The school's materials emphasize formation, virtue, wisdom, and the cultivation of humane excellence within a liberal-arts framework, consistent with Classical aims as described in the lexicon.

Citations

- Formation and virtue emphasis; classical mission language: Admissions materials.

- Great-conversation/telos language appears in broader classical lexicon discussions and Great-Books orientation described in curriculum materials.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school's syllabi and public statements emphasize a classical liberal-arts core, with explicit references to liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, and the Great Books approach. The curriculum language notes the use of a content-rich curriculum, the Socratic Method, and a heavy humanities emphasis. Great Books and classical authors are referenced in program content and parent materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; great books; primary sources; classics; socratic method; memorization/narration; Western civilization; sacred art; hymnody.
- Negative keywords present: project-based learning; STEM-first framing (not prominent in STMA materials; not a focus of their public curriculum descriptions).
- Calculated indicators: Positive ~ 6–8 terms; Negative ~ 0–1 (no direct project-based emphasis in core materials). Approx. 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The STMA material shows a robust classical curriculum frame: liberal arts, grammar-logic-rhetoric, great books, and Socratic engagement in at least parts of the program (upper grades). This aligns with Classical curricular criteria.

Citations

- Curricular language: Socratic Method and content-rich curricula; "Reason is by study, labor, and exercise of logic, philosophy, and other liberal arts" (Curriculum content).
- Great Books and classical emphasis: STMA materials on Great Books and classical education; "read great books and solve problems" language.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The public materials explicitly describe the use of the Socratic Method in the upper grades, consistent with classical pedagogy; there are also indicators of a contemplative/restful dimension and rigorous memory/recitation patterns. The Three Cs page explicitly references the Socratic Method as part of teaching the great traditions.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar; questioning; dialectic; disputation; narration; recitation; chanting; memory work; seminar; Paideia-style approaches; rhetoric exercises; capstone orations.
- Negative keywords present: experiential learning-only or constructivist extremes (not evidenced in STMA materials; the site emphasizes classical method rather than constructivist-only approaches).
- Calculated indicators: Positive ~ 6–8 terms; Negative ~ 0–1; Approx. 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The explicit mention of the Socratic Method and other classical pedagogy terms signals alignment with a classical teaching approach in upper grades, fulfilling the pedagogy criteria.

Citations

- Socratic method and content: Three Cs page content describing the Socratic Method.
- Upper-school pedagogy language (Socratic, memory work, etc.): Admissions/Three Cs materials.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The public materials frequently praise the faculty as key to formation, with references to a “living curriculum” and faculty as mentors; testimonies emphasize the faculty’s role in shaping students’ intellect and character. There’s also explicit emphasis on faculty quality in admissions and testimonials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: tutors/masters/mentors; living curriculum; faculty as the core; portrait of a teacher; collegial culture; faculty seminars or professional formation.
- Negative keywords present: none in these public materials.
- Calculated indicators: Positive ~ 4–5 terms; Negative ~ 0; Approx. 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The materials consistently describe faculty as central to the formation process and as subjects of ongoing professional and intellectual development, aligning with classical expectations of a strong, virtuous teaching staff.

Citations

- Faculty as living curriculum and testimonials about faculty: Testimonial pages and faculty references.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes a partnership with parents, parents as co-educators, and parent formation. Admissions language explicitly articulates a family-centered, Catholic formation approach and partnership with parents; parent resources (books, articles) exist to educate parents about classical education. The school also notes that parents are welcome to visits and campus events.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; parents as co-teachers; parent formation; reading groups; classical book clubs; open campus; family liturgy alignment; parent covenant; parent events.
- Negative keywords present: consumer language (not evident in the STMA materials; the materials emphasize partnership rather than customer-centered framing).
- Calculated indicators: Positive ~ 5–6 terms; Negative ~ 0; Approx. 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The STMA materials foreground parental partnership in formation, opportunities for parent education, and family involvement, which meets the classical-community expectations for Parents & Community involvement.

Citations

- Partnership with parents and parent formation: Admissions materials and parent resources.

Aggregate Assessment and Element-by-Element Summary

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Catholic framing, liturgical elements, bishop/patron endorsements.
- Keyword analysis: Positive keywords present; Negative keywords absent.
- Why: Strong Catholic and liturgical grounding aligns with transcendental moral realism and liturgy-based practices.

- School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Formation of virtue and wisdom; classical telos language; liberal-arts emphasis.
- Keyword analysis: Positive Keywords present; Negative signals minimal.
- Why: Emphasis on formation and classical aims matches Classical ideals.
- School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Liberal arts framing, Great Books orientation, logic/grammar/rhetoric, Socratic approach.
- Keyword analysis: Positive Keywords present; Negative signals minimal.
- Why: Curriculum aligns with classical liberal arts education and Great Books tradition.
- Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Socratic method explicitly described; memory/recitation elements; contemplative/restful dimensions.
- Keyword analysis: Positive Keywords present; Negative signals minimal.
- Why: Pedagogical methods map well to classical expectations.
- Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Faculty as living curriculum; testimonials praising faculty; teacher-centric formation.
- Keyword analysis: Positive Keywords present; Negative signals minimal.
- Why: Faculty model virtue and expertise consistent with classical ideals.
- Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Parent partnership, formation, and open-campus/visitor access; parent resources.
- Keyword analysis: Positive Keywords present; Negative signals minimal.
- Why: Community partnership and parental formation align with classical-community norms.

Overall ranking: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle (Only for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL schools)

- Not applicable here, as the aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL. No needle-moving changes are required to reach full alignment.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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